

The House at 862 Arlington Avenue and Marion E. Copley

Many of the descendants of Michael J. Copley, that is, his children and grandchildren either grew up in, or spent time in his beautiful old house located on the corner of Arlington Ave. and Mendocino St. in Berkeley, CA. This house was originally built by a Detroit heiress named Minnie Clough and her mother who had moved to Berkeley after the death of Minnie's father. Her late father, along with partners had founded a highly successful piano company back in Detroit. Minnie and her mother used their share of their inheritance to fund the building of this magnificent structure on The Arlington. Originally built right before World War 1, it was designed by award-winning Berkeley architect. Horace Simpson who designed several other buildings in the area. Many have said that the house shares many of the qualities of a French country home.

Minnie was quite distinguished as the founder of the first Montessori School in Berkeley, and continued to own the house until 1925 when she retired to Carmel. She sold the house to an insurance agent, who later sold it to Monroe Deutsch, who was Vice President and Provost of U.C. Berkeley. Deutsch was a well known civil rights activist who strongly opposed internment camps for U.S. citizens of Japanese ancestry during World War 2. Deutsch sold the house to our father, Michael, in 1947, which he then occupied along with his family up until his death in 1988. As part of the settlement of our father's estate, Tom Copley bought out Steve's interest in the house and continued to live there with his family until 2002. The house then was transferred to Tom's two children, Zach and Erin, and their respective spouses. Finally, Erin and her husband, Bryan Bird bought out Zach and his wife, Wendy. Tom and Dee moved to an apartment in neighboring Richmond, and Zach and Wendy moved to a house in nearby El Cerrito. Bryan and Erin continue to occupy and own the family home to this present day.

A short bio on our mother, Marion E. (Partlow) Copley

Our mother, Marion, who many of you have personally met, was an outstanding figure, and good partner for our father, Michael. They met at the University of Illinois, Urbana while our father was an Assistant Professor of Chemistry, and she was training to become an English teacher. Both took a great interest in helping young people to learn which had its obvious benefits for both of us. They spent endless hours tutoring us and making sure we were prepared for school. We can never forget the patience and good nature of these two individuals who were our parents.

Marion grew up on a farm in the Southern Illinois community of Casey. You can take the girl away from the farm, but you can never take the farm away from the girl. Our mother had a lifelong interest in growing things whether it be on the farm land she inherited from her parents or in her own back yard growing irises, roses, and native plants. There were many other horticultural things that she loved so much. She continued to manage the acres she inherited often advising the farmer on which crops to plant, the proper fertilizers to use, and crop rotation protocols.

She was also a local activist, and almost single-handedly raised a petition to save the Tilden Botanical Garden which the local park administrators were threatening to abandon. She succeeded in saving the Garden, and it still exists to this day. She also wrote a weekly column on California Native Plants for the local paper, "The Oakland Tribune."

Our mother was a brilliant writer who penned many novels and poems. A few were published, but many were never actually printed and ended up in various files that we are still sorting out almost 50 years after her passing in 1977. She was a wonderful mother, and an inspiring leader. We were definitely blessed to be her sons.